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Holst, Sofie; Petersen, Morten Krogh; Poulsen, Mathias; Lindek, Alexandra Harder; Schmidauer, Maximilian

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Sofie Holst
Kolding School of Design

Morten Krogh Petersen
Kolding School of Design

Mathias Poulsen
Kolding School of Design

Alexandra Lindek
Kolding School of Design

Maximilian Schmidauer
Kolding School of Design

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NORDES 2025

DESIGNING WITH RURAL MOBILITIES: ATTEMPTS AT RELATIONAL DESIGN

SOFIE BUNDGAARD HOLST
KOLDING SCHOOL OF DESIGN
SBH@DSKD.DK

MORTEN KROGH PETERSEN
KOLDING SCHOOL OF DESIGN
MKP@DSKD.DK

MATHIAS POULSEN
KOLDING SCHOOL OF DESIGN
MP@DSKD.DK

ALEXANDRA HARDER LINDEK
KOLDING SCHOOL OF DESIGN
AL@DSKD.DK

MAXIMILIAN SCHMIDAUER
KOLDING SCHOOL OF DESIGN
2023K021@DSKD.DK

ABSTRACT

This exploratory paper contributes to the development of relational design as a methodology by examining how relational design unfolds – and fails to unfold – throughout our participation in the research and development project *Mobility Makers: Customizing Sustainable Mobility Mixes to Fit Users' Needs* (MM). Mobilities create and disrupt relations, making our engagement in the MM project particularly suitable for investigating where and how relational design operates and the effects it can hope to achieve. Specifically, we analyze how relational design, when developed by relating to everyday mobilities, project partners, and mobilities studies, is nurtured, constrained, and problematized. We emphasize that designing relationally is an *act* and advocate for further research into the goods and bads of relational design as a design methodology supporting design researchers in relating to and designing with a troubled world.

INTRODUCTION

This paper asks: What can rural mobilities teach us about relational design? We ask this question – and more throughout the paper – through our current and ongoing participation in an Interreg North Sea development and research project, *Mobility Makers: Customizing Sustainable Mobility Mixes to Fit Users' Needs* (MM).

The project application argues that most earlier and related projects aiming to 'sustainabilize' mobilities have focused on developing and delivering new and more attractive mobility offerings. The MM project takes a different approach. It first seeks to understand the users' needs and then customize sustainable mobility mixes based on that understanding. The project runs from November 2023 to July 2027, involving 13 partners from the Netherlands, Belgium, Germany, France, Sweden, and Denmark. The Central Denmark Region leads the Danish contribution to the project in collaboration with Kolding School of Design. Further, we work closely with three municipalities in the Central Denmark Region, allowing us to ground the project empirically in the mobility practices unfolding there.

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Our narrative strategy in this exploratory paper aims to allow you to get under the hood of how we have wrestled with and sought to turn the notion of relational design into a workable design methodology. This experimental work is far from done – and hopefully, it will never be – as that would go against our main point: As a design methodology, the value of relational design lies in the deep curiosity it fosters about what the world consists of and how the world continuously is brought into being. We build on Escobar's deceptively simple advice for understanding and designing with ontological relationality: "One general principle I find useful is that a relational ontology is that within which nothing preexists the relations that constitute it" (Escobar, 2018, p. 161). As a design methodology, relational design, thus, is not a theoretically informed lens through which we can hope to make sense of pre-existing, stable realities. It is rather a methodology for relating to and taking part in creating worlds through design. Following that principle, we have chosen to open the hood to three project activities, which have nurtured, constrained, and problematized our relational ambitions. We hope that this narrative strategy allows you to relate to these project activities less as pre-established final facts about our work but as curiosity-sparking stories about relations made and broken and the ontological effects of such making and breaking. We aim to offer openings into what relational design might become, rather than closures and conclusions about what it is.

The three project activities are designing relationally with everyday mobilities, with project partners and funding bodies, and with mobilities studies.

DESIGNING RELATIONALLY WITH EVERYDAY MOBILITIES

We have developed and experimented with the approach of relay conversations to design relationally with the everyday mobilities unfolding in the three municipalities. The relay conversations are held in situ, mirroring mobilities researcher, Ole B. Jensen's plea to understand mobilities as sociomaterial, situational practices (Jensen, 2014). This insistence on 'being there' with our interlocutors also allows us and our interlocutors to bring a heterogeneous host of nearby actors participating in such situational mobility practice into the conversation. Second, we ask our interlocutors to formulate batons that they pass on to the subsequent interlocutors, enabling us to trace and make connections. During autumn 2024, we conducted a total of 23 relay conversations with 29 citizens (for an in-depth description of the relay conversation approach, see Lindek and Poulsen, accepted). We now turn to one of these relay conversations.

We, a husband and wife and two design researchers, met on a windy and grey October day in 2024 on the peninsula of Helgenæs. Helgenæs is part of Eastern Jutland, Denmark. Its landscape, softly curving into hills made during the ice age, allows your eyes and thoughts to wander without disturbance.

Looking like it just landed from above, on a small hilltop, a new, modernistic house was built. Living here is the husband and wife, a middle-aged couple, who moved here 4 years ago. Before that, they lived nearby in a small rural village composed of small, dense buildings. The husband pictured their previous village as "hidden between the hills" (Conversation, 17.10.24). Even though they lived in a rural area, they did not feel connected to the landscape and weather – the hills protected them. They dreamt about more air, light, and space around them, to see the ocean, and only be surrounded by the sounds of nature. On a bike trip, the husband saw the plot of land upon which their new home was built. The couple fondly describes the stillness of the place, the lives of the wild animals stealing food from their fruit trees, how the wind is casting, how they can see the stars and the northern lights so brightly, as well as how they can follow the changes of the seasons by the sun's orbit. Their jobs require them to move flexibly to most parts of Denmark, so they are often in their cars. They describe one key effect of moving to Helgenæs: "Our world has become smaller since we moved here, but we move a lot more" (Conversation, 17.10.24). Relational effects of mobilities – in this case, enacting a smaller world through driving more than ever – are, thus, not only of interest to adventurous academics (Lee and Ingold, 2020, see also Massey, 2005). Relational effects are also a lived experience for these interlocutors – how can they become so for the relational designer as well?

When the couple discusses their everyday mobilities and wishes for the future, they do not focus on more effective, streamlined transportation opportunities to the bigger cities. Instead, they talk about freedom and safety, that is, being able, on foot, to cross the neighboring privately owned fields to reach the sea. They mention paths in the landscape, tucked away from heavy traffic, connecting the people, institutions, services, shops, nature sites, and leisure spots. People born and raised in Helgenæs know this well. They, the long-lasting locals, know, for instance, how to cross the fields on foot without disturbing the growth and the harvest. They call the local landowners to agree on how to move across their land when riding their horses. As relative newcomers, the family is still learning. Another example: The husband tells us that when they first moved to Helgenæs four years ago, he disagreed with the local community's fondness for and their stressing of the importance of the local grocery store. Not too long ago, his daughter started working at the grocery store, telling him stories about the everyday happenings unfolding there. Through these conversations, he discovered that the grocery store is not just about the groceries. The grocery store is also a hub where people

meet and have conversations. Events hosted in and by the community are planned and promoted. Discussions are had about the pros and cons of organic vs. nonorganic groceries in exactly that local grocery store and community. Driving 30 minutes to buy organic groceries, as the couple does, has local, ontological effects, the husband's story tells us. It might take a daughter's new job to make such local effects apparent and felt.

Relating to everyday mobilities through fieldwork nurtures the methodology of relational design. But how, exactly? It is a step away from identifying isolated problems that might be solved through this or that designed artifact (Dorst, 2019). Local issues are continuously identified, discussed, and handled in the rural areas we have explored. Also, it is not about seeking inspiration for design ideas in the field, as this, to the methodology of relational design, is a strangely detached and designer-centric activity (Buchenau and Fulton Suri, 2000). It is, however, a step towards tracing existing relations and their effects. Much like the husband learning about existing relations and their effects through his daughter's part-time job in the grocery store, relational design can embrace both planned and serendipitous strategies of becoming connected.

DESIGNING RELATIONALLY WITH PROJECT PARTNERS AND FUNDING BODIES

The MM project aims to "create and implement user-centered mobility mixes through better understanding users' needs and incentivizing them to change their (perceptions of their) daily mobility practices" (see https://www.interregnorthsea.eu/mm, accessed 11 February 2025).

There are many possible ways to approach the issue of creating and implementing less resource-intensive rural mobilities. The title and the aims of the MM project suggest a specific one. This approach is premised upon the idea that the users' needs can, first, be located and described and, second, that mobility mixes can be developed to fit those needs. Further, this approach suggests that if we get the needs and the mobility mixes right, we can incentivize users to change their daily mobility behavior. However, as Escobar reminded us in the introduction, needs, like everything else in the world, come into being – and can wither away – as users engage with and relate to, for instance, companies and their products and services, public services, landscapes, and more-than-human co-inhabitants. We saw examples above: the family's move from the rural villages to Helgenæs, the husband learning that engaging with the local grocery store might, actually, become one of his everyday needs.

The MM project's title and aims seem to assume that it is possible to know these needs in advance and then go on to design for such needs. Such a framing reduces the design challenge to shifting from knowing to designing. But through our field engagements, we are reminded, again and again, that "to design is the opposite of taking things for granted" (Redström, 2020, p. 84). As Rittel and Webber famously argued, "part of the art of dealing with wicked problems is the art of not knowing too early which type of solution to apply" (Rittel and Webber, 1973, p. 164). The trouble is that Interreg North Sea, which partly funds the MM project, and many similar funding bodies demand linearity, in this case, first knowing the needs and then designing for these needs. And the challenge is that the partners in this project are requested to show linearity and progress in their activities and financial reporting. How to work with this? How can relational design be put to work within a project constellation that demands linearity and progress?

The relay conversation as storied in the above supports an understanding of creative mobility practices as emerging from everyday life; "from more-than-human mobile entanglements and should not be examined in isolation as merely an individual and innovative practice" (Jóhannesson et al., 2023, p. 5). The MM project's international partners meet physically twice a year, and we try to enable our project partners to relate to the mobile entanglements of our field through rich stories and photographs from our sites. We have invited our national partners to workshops inspired by Adele Clarke's situational analysis (Clarke et al., 2022, see also Nold, 2023), which also puts ontological relationality front and center. Design researcher Carl DiSalvo puts into words our experiments with enabling our project collaborators to "becoming-with" (Haraway, 2008, p. 16) creative and emergent mobility practices: "Simply enabling others to participate in design as we know it, as we are familiar with it, and as it is comfortable will be insufficient for imagining and instantiating other associations. To ask the question 'How might we live together, differently?' we also have to ask 'How might we design together, differently'" (DiSalvo, 2022, p. 242)? We can add: What kinds of project constellations and activities would aid us and our project partners to become-with the issue of sustainable mobilities as it unfolds in the rural areas of interest in the MM project?

DESIGNING RELATIONALLY WITH MOBILITIES STUDIES

As we hope to have shown through our re-telling of the relay conversation above, exploring rural mobilities in the field means "putting one foot in a relational world (or worlds)" (Escobar, 2018, p. 165). Conversely, relationality can face challenging conditions in project

constellations like MM. However, pursuing relationality in designing with rural mobilities again gains traction when relating to the disciplinary field of mobilities studies. It is a specific way of relating to mobilities studies and the field's key concepts, however. We saw an example in the above when we related a quote from the relay conversation to Lee and Ingold (2020) and Massey (2005). We did not try to get at some more profound truth hidden behind what was said. Instead, we sought to extend and strengthen the quote by relating it to literature. We extended and strengthened a specific way of thinking about relationality and ontological effects of mobilities that can help us handle rural mobilities (see Mol, 2021).

In a seminal article, sociologist Mimi Sheller argues that "[…] mobilities research has instigated a creative recombination of existing theoretical traditions, methodological approaches, epistemologies, and even ontologies of a world constituted by relations rather than entities […]" (Sheller 2014, p. 790). Relational design, as we develop and question it here, is, exactly, about coming to grips with "ontologies of a world constituted by relations rather than entities," as Sheller puts it. But how, exactly? How to design relationally with insights from mobilities studies.

Dealing with airborne mobilities and the noise airplanes produce above – and at the ground of and beyond – Heathrow Airport, design researcher Christian Nold sets up a choice for the designer engaging with such mobilities between a modernist design approach and one, which Nold terms practice-based ontological design: "A modernist design approach might focus on the material infrastructure such as the aircraft to make them more efficient and less polluting. While this is worthwhile, this case study demonstrates that practice-based ontological design can do something different and identify surprising sites for design. The airport consists of a material infrastructure of runways as well as an institutional infrastructure of representatives, but the controversy also has an ontological infrastructure that enables and prohibits particular realities" (Nold, 2018, p. 61). There is a resonance here: A modernist design approach works in a world constituted by entities, while practice-based ontological design works in a world of relations and the particular realities these particular relations enact.

In our case of rural mobilities, a modernist and entities-focused design approach would be materialized through, for instance, optimizing and streamlining car designs, developing car-sharing apps that are easier and more pleasing to use, or designing branding and marketing campaigns aiming to incentivize the locals to choose more sustainable forms of mobility. But such an approach may miss the mark. Not only because mobilities studies, according to Sheller, have taken an interest in relational ontologies, but also because our interlocutors in the field already seem to know and live with relational worlds. Take the family from above: their wish for freedom led them to Helgenæs. However, it would be a mistake to understand this as freedom as it is portrayed in the liberal narrative, that is, freedom as implying "the *absence* of something" (Schultz, 2023, p. 61, italics in original). Instead, it is a form of freedom that results from the family gradually entangling itself into the local lives of families, environments, practices, landscapes, and more. In other words, the family's freedom depends on their entanglement with the often-tacit ways of acting with the local community.

Still, living in rural areas can imply long waits between bus departures, or realizing it is not coming at all. Sometimes, people in rural areas depend on others for a lift home. Sometimes, a lift comes quickly – sometimes, not at all. Could this be one of the "surprising sites for design" mentioned by Nold? How could the car lift infrastructure be strengthened? And what would the effects be – for the people, the place, and their relations? When snowstorms hit rural areas, these areas are low on the municipalities' priority lists. Instead, the community depends on a person with the skills to put available machines to work. And of this person's willingness to help (Shove et al., 2012). Willingness to help – through a lift, removing snow, or something else – is a general theme in our conversations with people living in rural areas about their mobility patterns. Willingness to help is a willingness to relate. But when, where, how, and why, exactly? Some locals want to help and relate, but express concerns about others becoming too dependent upon them. What if, one day, they are willing but unable to help? Maybe there is a lesson for relational design here: when and where to nurture and when and where to cut relations? Put differently: what are the goods and bads of relational design?

OPENINGS: FROM "ACTING ON" TO "ACTING WITH"

We hope to have shown that through our engagement in the MM project, we have encountered and engaged in a rich web of entangled relations between humans and more-than-humans, between people and the places where their lives unfold. We have also tried to bring such relational worlds into the worlds of our project partners. We argued that this is easier said than done, due to the organization of such projects into linear and clearly delineated sets of project activities: first knowing, then designing, implementing, and measuring results. But there is more to it. In the last section, we brought our work into conversation with the field of mobilities studies, which has recently taken a turn towards relationality. By revisiting the field with that set of resources and showing how relationalities and dependencies do not come without their own goods and

bads, we ended by asking questions concerning the ambiguities of relational design.

As a methodology, relational design can be understood as a search for ways for designers to act in a troubled world. Science and technology studies scholar Andrew Pickering distinguishes between a modern pattern of acting in the world, which he thinks of as "acting on the world" (Pickering, 2022, p. 156). To Pickering, this modern pattern of acting on the world is "what has gotten us into so much trouble" (Pickering, 2022, p. 156). The second pattern, which we may term a-modern (Latour, 1993), Pickering terms "acting with the world" (Pickering, 2022, p. 156): "Acting on the world presumes that we are the only agents around. Acting with acknowledges that that is not true: the world itself is a lively place that we need to collaborate with" (Pickering, 2022, p. 157). In this way, Pickering underscores the agency of human and non-human worlds alike. Relational design, we suggest with Pickering, does not dissolve the designer and her agency into the webby relations she latches onto, collaborates with, and, crucially, also extends. Relational design, as we have suggested here, is a specific way of acting with and attempting to expand the world. Through our narrative style of this exploratory paper, we have sought not to act on you, but to enable you to act and expand with us.

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